“Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta”

Ādi-līlā

Chapter 2

The Truth of Śrī Caitanya Mahāprabhu

(translated from the Bengali for this edition)

1 I worship Śrī Caitanya Mahāprabhu. By His mercy even a child can cross the ocean of conclusive truths, which is infested with the crocodiles of various doctrines.

2 O Śrī Caitanya, ocean of mercy! May the heavenly Gaṅgā of the nectar of Your resplendent pastimes flow through the desert courtyard of my tongue. Its lotuses are the arts of glorifying Kṛṣṇa aloud, of singing and of dancing. Rows of true devotees sport in it like swans, cakravāka birds and swarms of bees, and its sweet murmur delights the ears.

3 All glory, all glory to Śrī Caitanya! Glory to Nityānanda! Glory to Advaita-candra, and glory to all the devotees of Gaura!

4 Now I shall explain the meaning of the third verse, the invocation (*maṅgalācaraṇa*) that defines the subject.

5 “What the Upaniṣads call the non-dual Brahman is only the radiance of His body. The one called the Puruṣa, the Supersoul dwelling within all, is His plenary expansion. And Bhagavān, full of the six opulences, is He Himself. In this world there is no Supreme Truth higher than Caitanya, who is Kṛṣṇa.”

6 Brahman, the Supersoul and Bhagavān are the three subjects (*anuvāda*). The radiance of His body, His portion and His own form (*svarūpa*) are the three predicates (*vidheya*) that define them.

7 The subject comes first, and the predicate is placed after it. I shall tell you the meaning of the verse in this way; now hear it explained according to scripture.

8 Kṛṣṇa is the Supreme Lord Himself (*svayaṁ bhagavān*), the Supreme Truth of all Viṣṇu forms. He is full knowledge and full bliss, and His greatness is supreme.

9 That Kṛṣṇa, whom the Bhāgavatam glorifies as the son of Nanda, has descended as Lord Caitanya.

10 According to His particular manifestations He bears three names: Brahman, the Supersoul and Bhagavān, the Supreme Lord Himself.

11 "The knowers of the Truth declare that the Truth is non-dual knowledge. It is named Brahman, the Supersoul and Bhagavān." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 1.2.11)

12 The pure halo of rays from His body is what the Upaniṣads call the utterly pure Brahman.

13 To the physical eye the sun appears featureless. In the same way, on the path of knowledge one cannot grasp His distinctive features.

14 "I worship Govinda, the original Person. In the millions upon millions of universes of that mighty Lord, His effulgence appears differentiated by countless opulences, such as earths. That effulgence is Brahman — undivided, infinite and complete." (Brahma-saṁhitā 5.40)

15 Brahman, whose opulence fills millions upon millions of universes, is the luster of Govinda's body.

16 I worship that Govinda; He is my master. By His grace I have the power to create.

17 "Sages clad only in the wind, ascetics who draw their seed upward, peaceful and pure renunciants — they reach the abode called Brahman." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 11.6.47)

18 He whom the scriptures of yoga call the Self, the indwelling Lord (*antaryāmī*), is a portion of Govinda and a manifestation of His opulence.

19 Just as one sun is reflected in countless crystals, so Govinda's portion is manifest in all living beings.

20 "But what need is there, Arjuna, for you to know all this in detail? I pervade and support this entire universe with a single portion of Myself." (Bhagavad-gītā 10.42)

21 "My delusion of difference is gone, and I have realized Him, this unborn Lord. He abides in the heart of every embodied being He has created, just as the one sun appears in many ways to every eye that sees it." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 1.9.42)

22 That same Govinda is directly Lord Caitanya. No one else is so merciful in delivering souls.

23 In the spiritual sky resides the Lord named Nārāyaṇa. He is full of the six opulences and is the beloved of Lakṣmī.

24 The Vedas, the Bhāgavatam, the Upaniṣads and the Āgamas call Him "the complete Truth"; no one is equal to Him.

25 Through *bhakti-yoga*, the path of devotion, the devotees obtain the sight of Him, just as the gods see the sun in his personal form.

26 Those who worship Him on the paths of knowledge and yoga realize Him as Brahman and as the Supersoul.

27 One comes to know the greatness of the Lord according to the different kinds of worship. That is why I compare Him to the sun.

28 That Nārāyaṇa is non-different from Kṛṣṇa's own form. They are one and the same divine form (*vigraha*), but Their appearance differs.

29 Kṛṣṇa has two arms, and Nārāyaṇa has four. Kṛṣṇa holds the flute, and Nārāyaṇa holds the disc and His other emblems.

30 "O Lord, are You not Nārāyaṇa? You are the Self of all embodied beings and the witness of all the worlds. The one called Nārāyaṇa because His resting place is the water born of Nara is Your portion. And that portion too is real; it is not Your māyā." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 10.14.14)

31 Brahmā had offended Kṛṣṇa by stealing the cowherd boys and the calves. To have his offense forgiven, he begged for mercy:

32 "I was born from the lotus of Your navel. You are my father and mother, and I am Your son.

33 A father and mother do not take offense at what their child does. Forgive my offense and be merciful to me."

34 Kṛṣṇa said, "Brahmā, your father is Nārāyaṇa. I am a cowherd boy. How can you be My son?"

35 Brahmā said, “Are You not Nārāyaṇa? You are Nārāyaṇa — hear the reason why.

36 You are the Self of all the living beings in the material and the spiritual creation. You are their original source.

37 Just as the earth is the cause and the shelter of all pots, so You are the origin of all souls. You are the shelter of all.

38 The word *nāra* means the aggregate of all living beings, and the word *ayana* means their shelter.

39 Therefore You are the original Nārāyaṇa. That is the first reason; now hear the second.

40 The lords of the living beings are the Puruṣa and the other avatāras. Your opulence is boundlessly greater than Theirs.

41 Therefore You are the supreme Lord, the father of all. It is by Your potency that They protect the world.

42 Since You protect Those who are the shelter of the living beings, You are the original Nārāyaṇa.

43 O Lord, hear the third reason. There are countless universes and many abodes such as Vaikuṇṭha.

44 You see the deeds of all the beings in them, past, present and future. You are the witness, and You know the inner meaning of everything.

45 All the worlds exist by Your glance. If You did not look upon them, no one could either stay or move.

46 Since You see the course of all living beings, for this reason too You are the original Nārāyaṇa.”

47 Kṛṣṇa said, “Brahmā, I do not understand your words. Nārāyaṇa is He who resides in the hearts of the living beings and on the waters.”

48 Brahmā said, “The Nārāyaṇa who lies on the waters and dwells in the living beings — all these are Your portions. This is the truth.”

49 Kāraṇodakaśāyī, Garbhodakaśāyī and Kṣīrodakaśāyī create through māyā; therefore They are all called wielders of māyā (*māyī*).

50 These three Lords who lie on the waters dwell within all. The one named the Puruṣa is the Self of all the universes.

51 Garbhodakaśāyī is the Self of Hiraṇyagarbha, and Kṣīrodakaśāyī is the indwelling Lord of each individual being.

52 Because all these Lords cast Their glance upon māyā, a trace of māyā is associated with Them. But Kṛṣṇa, the fourth (*turīya*), has no connection with māyā.

53 “Virāṭ, Hiraṇyagarbha and the Cause are designations of the Lord. That which is free of these three is called the fourth (*turīya*).” (Śrīdhara Svāmī, commentary on Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 11.15.16)

54 Although these three deal with māyā, māyā does not touch Them. All of Them are beyond māyā.

55 “This is the divinity of the Lord: although He is within material nature, He is never touched by its qualities, though they always rest in Him. In the same way the intelligence of those who take shelter of Him remains untouched by them.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 1.11.38)

56 “You are the supreme shelter of these three. You are the original Nārāyaṇa — what doubt can there be?

57 The source of these three is Nārāyaṇa of the spiritual sky. He is Your manifestation, and You are the original Nārāyaṇa.”[1]

58 Thus, according to Brahmā’s words, Nārāyaṇa of the spiritual sky is a pastime form (*vilāsa*) of Kṛṣṇa. This is the explanation of the truth.

59 This verse defines the truth and is the essence of the Bhāgavatam. As a governing rule (*paribhāṣā*), it holds authority everywhere.

60 Brahman, the Supersoul and Bhagavān are manifestations of Kṛṣṇa. Not knowing this meaning, fools interpret the verse otherwise.

61 They say that Nārāyaṇa is the source of the avatāras and Kṛṣṇa is an avatāra, since Nārāyaṇa has four arms and Kṛṣṇa has a human form.

62 In this way they raise objections of many kinds. A verse of the Bhāgavatam is able to defeat them:

63 “The knowers of the Truth declare that the Truth is non-dual knowledge. It is named Brahman, the Supersoul and Bhagavān.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 1.2.11)

64 Listen, brothers, and consider the meaning of this verse. There is one principal Truth, and It has three manifestations.

65 The non-dual knowledge, the Absolute Reality, is Kṛṣṇa’s own form. Brahman, the Supersoul and Bhagavān are His three forms.

66 The meaning of this verse has left you speechless. Now hear another statement of the Bhāgavatam.

67 “All these are portions and parts of the Puruṣa, but Kṛṣṇa is Bhagavān Himself. Age after age They bring relief to the world when it is troubled by the enemies of Indra.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 1.3.28)

68 After describing the general features of all the avatāras, Sūta counted Kṛṣṇacandra among Them.

69 Then Sūta Gosvāmī grew very apprehensive and defined the distinctive characteristic of each.

70 All the avatāras are parts and portions of the Puruṣa, but Kṛṣṇa is the Supreme Lord Himself, the crown of all.

71 An opponent says, “A fine explanation you give! But Nārāyaṇa of the spiritual sky is the Supreme Lord Himself.

72 He comes and descends in the form of Kṛṣṇa. That is the meaning I see in the verse. What more is there to consider?”

73 The answer to him is this: “Why do you draw inferences by false logic? A meaning that contradicts scripture can never be proof.”

74 “One should not state the predicate without first stating the subject, for nothing without a footing can stand firm anywhere.” (Ekādaśī-tattva 13)

75 One does not state the predicate without first stating the subject. First one states the subject, and then the predicate.

76 The predicate is what is not yet known, and the subject is what is already known.

77 For example, we say, “This brāhmaṇa is a great scholar.” Here *brāhmaṇa* is the subject, and his learning is the predicate.

78 We know that he is a brāhmaṇa, but his learning is not known. Therefore *brāhmaṇa* comes first and his learning after.

79 In the same way, the avatāras here are all known, but whose avatāras They are is not known.

80 First the word *ete*, “these,” states the subject, the avatāras. Then the words “portions of the Puruṣa” state the predicate.

81 In the same way, Kṛṣṇa was known as one among the avatāras, but His distinctive nature was not known.

82 Therefore the word *Kṛṣṇa* comes first as the subject, and after it the predicate states that He is the Supreme Lord Himself.

83 Kṛṣṇa's being the Supreme Lord Himself is what must be established (*sādhya*); that the Supreme Lord Himself is Kṛṣṇa follows as a binding conclusion (*bādhya*).

84 If Kṛṣṇa were a portion and Nārāyaṇa the source, Sūta’s statement would have been the reverse.

85 He would have put it this way: “Nārāyaṇa, the source of the portions, the Supreme Lord Himself — He is Śrī Kṛṣṇa.”

86 Error, inattention, the wish to cheat and imperfect senses — none of these faults are found in the words of the wise sages.

87 You give a contradictory meaning, and when this is pointed out you become angry. Your interpretation has the fault called *avimṛṣṭa-vidheyāṁśa*, an ill-placed predicate.

88 The words “the Supreme Lord Himself” apply only to Him from whose divinity the others derive Theirs.

89 When many lamps are lit from one lamp, I count that one as the original lamp.

90 In the same way, Kṛṣṇa is the cause of all the avatāras. Now hear another verse, which refutes false interpretations.

91–92 “Here are described primary creation, secondary creation, maintenance, protection, the impetus for action, the reigns of the Manus, the narrations of the Lord, dissolution, liberation and the shelter. To make the tenth clearly known, the great souls describe the other nine here, plainly, by direct statement and by implied meaning.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 2.10.1–2)

93 I describe these nine categories so that the shelter may be known. The cause from which these nine arise — that is what *shelter* means.

94 Kṛṣṇa alone is the shelter of all; Kṛṣṇa is the abode of all. All the universes rest in His body.

95 “The Tenth Canto reveals the tenth subject, the embodiment of the shelter of all who take shelter. I bow to that supreme abode called Śrī Kṛṣṇa, the abode of the universe.” (Śrīdhara Svāmī, Bhāvārtha-dīpikā on Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 10.1.1)

96 One who knows Kṛṣṇa’s own form and His three potencies is never ignorant about Kṛṣṇa.

97 Kṛṣṇa’s own form has six kinds of pastime forms (*vilāsa*). His manifestations are of two kinds, *prābhava* and *vaibhava*.

98 His avatāras are of two kinds: partial avatāras and empowered avatāras (*śaktyāveśa*). There are two further kinds: His forms of childhood and of boyhood (*paugaṇḍa*).

99 Kṛṣṇa in His own youthful form (*kiśora*) is Himself the source of all avatāras. He sports in these six forms and fills the universe.

100 These six forms have endless varieties. Yet in all these endless forms He is one form; there is no difference at all.

101 The spiritual potency (*cit-śakti*) is called His very own potency (*svarūpa-śakti*) and the internal potency. Its opulence is the countless abodes such as Vaikuṇṭha.

102 The potency called māyā is external and is the cause of the material world. Its opulence is the countless multitudes of universes.

103 The potency of the living beings is called marginal (*taṭastha*), and it has no end. These are the three principal potencies, and their varieties are endless.

104 These are His own forms and the three potencies. Kṛṣṇa is the shelter of them all, and all of them exist in Kṛṣṇa.

105 Although the Puruṣa is the shelter of all the universes, Kṛṣṇa is the original shelter of the Puruṣa and of all the others.

106 Kṛṣṇa is the Supreme Lord Himself; Kṛṣṇa is the shelter of all. All the scriptures declare that Kṛṣṇa is the supreme Lord.

107 “Kṛṣṇa, who is Govinda, is the supreme Lord. His form is eternity, knowledge and bliss. He has no beginning, yet He is the beginning of all, the cause of all causes.” (Brahma-saṁhitā 5.1)

108 You know all these conclusions well, yet you raise objections to unsettle me.

109 That Kṛṣṇa, the son of the king of Vraja, the source of the avatāras, has Himself descended in the form of Caitanya.

110 Therefore Lord Caitanya is the utmost limit of the Supreme Truth. What glory is there in calling Him Kṣīrodaśāyī?

111 Yet such words of a devotee are not wrong. Everything is possible in Him, since He is the source of the avatāras.

112 All the avatāras exist within the body of Him who is their source. So people speak of Him in different ways, each according to his understanding.

113 Some call Kṛṣṇa Nara-Nārāyaṇa, and some say that Kṛṣṇa is Vāmana Himself.

114 Some say that Kṛṣṇa is an avatāra of Kṣīrodaśāyī. That is not impossible; the words of all of them are true.

115 Some call Him Hari, the Nārāyaṇa of the spiritual sky. Everything is possible in Kṛṣṇa, since He is the source of the avatāras.

116 I bow at the feet of all my listeners. Hear all these conclusions with undivided attention.

117 Do not let your heart grow lazy, thinking these are mere philosophical conclusions. Through them the mind becomes firmly attached to Kṛṣṇa.

118 Through all these conclusions one comes to know the greatness of Caitanya. Knowing His greatness, the heart grows firm and becomes

attached to Him.

119 To tell the greatness of Caitanya Mahāprabhu, I have described the greatness of Kṛṣṇa in detail.

120 This is the established truth about Lord Caitanya: He is Kṛṣṇa, the Supreme Lord Himself, the son of the king of Vraja.

121 Ever hoping for the mercy of the feet of Śrī Rūpa and Raghunātha, I, Kṛṣṇadāsa, narrate *Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta*.

Notes

1. The Gauḍīya Maṭha edition reads *prakāśa*, “manifestation,” which is translated here; other editions read *vilāsa*, “pastime form.” ↩